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Structure, Agency, and Culture: Examining the Influence of Organizational Culture in Succession Planning in Higher Education Institutions

by

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Abstract

Succession planning (SP, thereafter) is essential for leadership continuity and institutional sustainability, particularly within higher education institutions (HEIs) (Ahmad et al., 2020; Rothwell, 2005). While the corporate sector has extensively institutionalized SP, its adoption in state universities and colleges (SUCs) in the Philippines remains underexplored, with leadership transitions often influenced by organizational culture, bureaucratic constraints, and political dynamics (Brillantes & Perante-Calina, 2018; Palencia, 2022). Using qualitative methods, this study examines the extent to which organizational culture shapes SP within SUCs, analyzing leadership selection processes, structural barriers, and informal succession mechanisms (Chia, 2021; Ghazali et al., 2021). Findings reveal that while SUCs recognize the importance of leadership continuity, the absence of formal succession policies leads to inconsistent appointment practices and susceptibility to external political influences (Collins, 2013; McKee & Froelich, 2016; Umans et al., 2021). Furthermore, results highlight the tension between hierarchical governance structures and the necessity for more transparent and merit-based leadership development strategies (Bano et al., 2022; Besel et al., 2021). By contextualizing SP within Philippine SUCs, this study contributes to existing leadership development literature in HEIs and provides actionable recommendations for establishing structured and sustainable SP frameworks. The research underscores the importance of aligning SP with institutional culture to foster leadership stability, advocating for the adoption of systematic policies that balance organizational values with strategic succession mechanisms (Ghazali et al., 2021; Rothwell, 2011).

Introduction

Succession planning has long been recognized as a vital strategy employed by various organizations to ensure leadership continuity, stability, and the achievement of long-term goals (Ahmad et al., 2022; Atwood, 2007; Jayme et al., 2013; Rothwell, 2005; Siambi, 2022). It involves, among others, identifying potential leaders, developing and mentoring them, and establishing structures that facilitate smooth transitions (Ahmad et al., 2024; Barnet & Davis, 2008; Mehrabani & Mohamad, 2011; Okwakpam, 2019; Rothwell, 2011; Sambrook, 2005).

Literature reveals that effective succession planning is widely recognized for its role in strengthening organizational resilience, maintaining knowledge continuity, and fostering sustained growth (Appelbaum et al., 2012; Hatcher, 2023). Albeit used mainly by business organizations (chiefly large corporations), recent literature has revealed the growing interest of scholars in the use of SP in academic settings, particularly in institutions of higher learning (Barton, 2019; Chia, 2021; Ghazali et al., 2023; Hatcher, 2023; King, 2019; Lloyd & Wolstencroft, 2022; Morrow, 2023; Owusu et al., 2022; Richard, 2009; Romero, 2021; Shamsuddin, 2012; Swanson, 2018; Tahir et al., 2023).

For academic institutions, however, SP poses unique challenges (Chia, 2021). Leadership transitions in these contexts necessitate striking a balance between the pursuit of academic excellence and the need for stable governance structures, while addressing the diverse needs of faculty, students, and other stakeholders (Ghazali et al., 2021; Omar & Hassan, 2015).

Although literature affirms the benefits of well-planned leadership transitions (Ahmad et al., 2022; Atwood, 2007; Jayme et al., 2013; Rothwell, 2005; Siambi, 2022), many institutions still face obstacles in establishing effective succession planning, often due to underlying structural,

cultural, and external complexities that impact these processes (Bano et al., 2022; Besel et al., 2021; Collins, 2013; McKee & Froelich, 2016; Mwemezi, 2011; Umans, et al., 2021).

In the Philippines, SP in state universities and colleges (henceforth, SUCs) face additional layers of complexity shaped by the distinctive organizational culture, bureaucratic constraints, and influence of political dynamics inherent to public institutions (Brillantes & Perante-Calina, 2018; Jaymalin-Dulay, 2021; Palencia, 2022). While formal policies for leadership continuity exist, little research has examined how cultural and institutional factors specifically impact these processes within SUCs in the Philippines. Thus, this study aims to explore the nuanced role of organizational culture in shaping succession planning within SUCs. This research further examines the visible practices and the hidden mechanisms that influence SP, contributing to a deeper understanding of leadership transitions and addressing a gap in the literature on higher education governance in the Philippines.

Review of Related Literature

Concepts of Succession Planning

The idea of succession planning was pioneered in the early 20th century by Henri Fayol, a management expert who believed that current management has an essential role in ensuring an organization's stability and continuity through the strategic development of leadership skills and characteristics (Siambi, 2022).

Despite its early emergence, it was only in the latter part of the 1960s and early part of the 1970s that businesses took cognizance of SP's importance largely as a response to the emergence of leadership challenges faced by various companies at that time (Bano et al., 2022). Early notable

studies (Coleman, 1970; Trow, 1961; Zaich, 1986) in SP were mainly focused on workforce planning and executive succession as it was traditionally practiced decades ago that SP concentrated only on the people and not on their competencies (Garman & Tyler, 2004). As Mehrabani and Mohamad (2011) put it: "the only purpose of succession planning was to tag and identify the needed successors to replace their ancestors for a specific job" (p. 371).

Since then, the concept of SP has been adopted by various sectors (business, public institutions, and education) of society, where leadership succession has been notably imperative as a strategy for organizational continuity and stability (Ahmad et al., 2020; Rothwell, 2005). Over time, due to its pervasive use and application in various sectors and contexts, particularly in the business sector, succession planning's definition has evolved, thereby providing a much broader and encompassing area of inquiry across various aspects of an organization, which includes among others HR, sustainability leadership, and educational leadership (Rothwell, 2005). These definitions have provided scholars with diverse research directions and study scopes, thus widening the debate and offering new perspectives regarding SP.

Scholars have proposed various definitions of SP, and they can be loosely categorized into two distinct groups: the broad and general definition and the sector-specific definition. One of these general definitions is that of Jayme et al. (2013). They define SP as a process involving long-term preparation to develop replacements for key positions to maintain continuous leadership within an organization. Atwood (2007), however, did not only include leadership positions but included all employees in SP. She defined SP as a tool institutions use to organize and replace administrators, supervisors, and other employees when they leave their posts, which is crucial for their long-term success.

SP, according to Okwakpam (2019), involves ensuring that organizations hire and continually enhance the skills of their staff to fill critical roles within the organization. In the same vein, Barnett and Davis (2008) provided another broad definition, which states that succession planning is a process that involves identifying and preparing internal candidates to take on important roles within the organization. This time, putting emphasis on the importance of internal talent pool within the organization, an idea which runs counter with Deshwal (2015) and Charan (2004) who put hiring external employees as a key element to SP. For Sambrook (2005), SP is a process that involves preparation for the correct quantity and caliber of managers and highly skilled employees to address retirement, death, severe illness, or advancement, as well as any forthcoming positions in the organizations plans. For Armstrong and Taylor (2014) SP is just part of the larger HR function known in the industry as talent management.

However, some studies (e.g. Ali & Mehreen, 2019; Chan et al. 2020; Fancher, 2007; Seniwoliba, 2015) have argued that while SP falls under the HR's function, incumbent leaders of the organization have an important role to play and their commitment matters in the successful institutionalization of an SP strategy. Lastly, and perhaps the widely used and accepted definition in SP scholarship is that of Rothwell (2001). He defines SP as "a deliberate and systematic effort by an organization to ensure leadership continuity in key positions, retain and develop intellectual and knowledge capital for the future, and encourage individual advancement" (p. 29).

As earlier noted, pioneering studies on SP had been focused largely on top management replacement. Due to this practice and limitation, SP, has, for a time being and to a certain extent, been synonymous and used interchangeably to replacement planning- a risk management strategy that is used to replace top managers before they leave their offices (Burdett, 1993). Hence, early scholars had used replacement planning instead of succession planning in their studies (e.g.

Carnazza, 1982; Kesner & Sebora, 1994). However, Rothwell and Poduch (2004), in the context of public management, made a distinction between the two for clearer understanding of their use and scope. They argue that replacement planning is just "planning for senior-level backups" and "just about finding replacement" while SP does not only involve replacement but also "developing talent and building sufficient bench strength, and preserving the organization's institutional memory" (p. 405). Contrary to some criticisms in the literature, succession planning is not just about filling in gaps in leadership hierarchy. As Siambi (2022) puts it: "In essence, leadership succession planning is not mere vacancy planning but a proactive approach to systemic development of leadership capabilities for with a long-term perspective" (p. 18).

Furthermore, Rothwell and Poduch (2004) even stretched SP's definition to make a clear difference between technical and managerial SP. For them technical SP is about developing talents across the horizontal spectrum with "specialized knowledge" while managerial SP focused only on the vertical spectrum of the organizational chart or simply put, the leaders of an organization (p. 406). Here, Rothwell and Poduch challenged the traditionally held view that SP is exclusive only for future leadership roles, but instead widens and expands the scholarship to include other members of the organization by putting spotlight on the critical role they play in the continuity and stability of the organization.

Elsewhere, in the context of family-owned enterprises, scholars took cognizance of the term written and oral succession planning referring to formal SP and informal SP (Kitayi, 2017). Given these definitions alongside the studies made some 50 years ago and thereafter, SP has been generally focused on the individuals and not on developing the competencies they ought to possess (Mehribini & Mohamad, 2011).

Conceptual Models

From these definitions, various models designed by a handful of SP scholars have emerged to address the universality or the specificity of SP needs by different organizations. Most frameworks of succession planning have been largely designed for business sector and have been widely used at that. Absury (1947, in Mehrabani & Mohamad, 2011) is perhaps the first scholar to introduce critical elements to SP. He identified "organization analysis, selection, evaluation, development of executive level talent, and inventory control" (p. 372).

Christensen (1953, in Mehrabani & Mohamad, 2011) also identified elements that must be included in SP and they are "identifying the pool of potential successors, the actual designation of the successor, and the notification of both the successor designated and other major power figures" (p. 372). In the same vein, Chapman (1954, in Mehrabani & Mohamad, 2011) suggested five elements for executive development programs. These are elements are "defined organization plan, performance appraisal, established replacement tables, development of high potentials, job rotation, and training programs" (372).

Notable of these models is the framework proposed by Rothwell (2001, 2005), a seven-step framework which focuses not only on the possible replacement for leadership roles but puts emphasis on identifying critical roles in the organization that are most vital in sustaining stability and effectiveness. Employees with potential are early on identified and provided with necessary skills through training and development to prepare them to take on the role should vacancy due to various reasons (e.g. retirement, resignation, death) arise. Another key element present in this model is the notion of institutional knowledge transfer. Rothwell (2005) posits that not only skills are imperative for SP, but also the transfer of institutional knowledge. A concept akin to institutional memory, unique to individual leaders and employees, which is developed and

accumulated over their tenure within the organization. This, according to him, must be passed on to the next leader through a transition period, a moment when the successor is mentored and trained shortly before the incumbent finally leaves the office. This transition period will enable successors to smoothly navigate well in their new roles when they finally assume the office, thereby avoiding the need for costly and time-consuming onboarding trainings on the part of the organization (Rothwell, 2005).

Finally, the model supports long-term target setting insofar as building and retaining new breed of leaders are concerned as it also puts premium on evaluating the effects of leadership transition, loss of institutional knowledge and the cost of hiring new leaders outside the organization.

Theoretical Models

In summarizing existing theoretical constructs for SP, Richards (2010) categorized theoretical models into three major groups namely: universalistic, contingency, and configurational. Universalistic approach believes in best practices and in the idea of one-size-fits-all (Hamid, 2013). Early studies on SP had largely advocated for the adoption of best practices across organizations. This suggestion of uniformity arises from the notion that some practices are way better than the others and hence must be embraced and adopted by other organizations (Armstrong, 2014).

Many scholars, however, were quick to criticize the inapplicability of this approach in some respect. Cavanaugh (2017) argued that a universalistic approach may hinder institutions from creatively formulating novel, culturally and contextually relevant practices that fit their own needs. Kaufman (2010) also observed that while this approach has been relatively successful in the United State and the United Kingdom, studies outside these countries have not been corroborative in

proving the benefits it purports to claim. Hence the emergence of contingency and resource-based-view theories. On the one hand, contingency theory is a human resources management construct that believes that enhanced organizational performance depends on the coordination of specific HR management methods within the organization. Simply put, SP as an approach to improve institutional performance, must come from within the organization and must be based on existing practices.

On the other hand, resource-based-view theory has a similar perspective but emphasizes that in order to have a more competitive advantage, HR must use their resources to create practices that are unique to their organization and "cannot be easily imitated" (Siambi, 2022, p. 21). For SP's context, this means that adopting the best practices approach as forwarded by the universalistic theory cannot hold true when we talk of the organization's competitive advantage. In summary, these theories give credence to the formulation of organization specific SP plans that fit within their own needs, resources, and contexts. As Shamsuddin and colleagues, (2012) write:

> Authorities are urged to not make complete adoption of existing models, which do not fit well with subtleties of the local scene, resulting in hiccups and paralysis of the HEI's governance and administrative organs. In other words, an all-encompassing mold must be cast to cater for the needs, context and factors that make up our HEIs, without which we will be encumbered by a perpetual game of merry-go-round, never finding the way forward (p 151).

Succession Planning in Higher Education

As more and more organizations face talent management and leadership crises and as empirical studies on SP have provided evidence supporting its benefits, organizations like medical institutions (Beyers, 2006; Blouin et al., 2006; Bolton & Roy, 2004; Cadmus, 2006; Crosby & Shields, 2010), libraries (Fallon et al,. 2013; Bridgland, 1999, Fitsomons, 2013; Huynh, 2016),

and higher education institutions (henceforth, HEI) have turned to SP as a strategy to mitigate them.

Higher education perhaps is the last among these sectors to apply the construct of SP in their context. HEIs in the first world countries like the United States, United Kingdom, and Canada are first to introduce SP into their system largely attributed to the inevitable cascading effects of SP from companies and the shift of these universities from traditional educational management prototype to a more corporate model of administration (Thomas, 2013).

Among the first scholars to explore SP in HEI was Richard (2009) in her study of six educational institutions (community and technical colleges, public research universities, and private universities) in the US using grounded theory as an approach, she observed that despite widespread leadership development activities, very few of these institutions had formal succession planning. She attributed this to instances of how academic governance and culture may have impacted the approaches to succession planning of these institutions. From these observations, she suggested five strategies HEI may consider in implementing deliberate and systematic succession plans. She called this 5Cs: Strategies for Succession Planning in the Academy:(Champions, Culture, Competency-based, Communication, Continuous).

Using these 5Cs of Richards (2009), Barton (2017) took SP into a new perspective doing an ethnographic case study of a US Chirstian higher education institution to come up with context-specific observations that could be considered in institutionalizing an intentional SP. He was concerned that despite Christian HEIs accounting to one fifth of the colleges and universities in the US, "relatively few studies have addressed succession planning… in Christ-centered higher education in particular." (Barton, 2017, p. 37). His study identified nine themes related to succession planning culture and leadership development that he believes that the top management

need to consider as they have significant implications for the university's future. These themes are as follow: (a) developing next leaders is the President's to priority; (b) influential historic, cultural, and religious norms shape the context; (c) participants have a clear understanding of the purpose of the programs; (d) valuable exposure and interaction with other leaders are emphasized; (e) participants deeply value their engagement in programs; (f) importance of making intentional and ongoing plans for participants; (g) succession planning efforts are a priority for the board of trustees and; (h) it is critical to intentionally develop leaders who understand the changing landscape of higher education.

Also using the case study lens, Swanson (2018) centered his investigation on the perceptions of HEI employees about SP in a community college setting. He opined that gaining insight into employees' viewpoints on SP can help assess strategic importance of SP in organizations. Results show what most scholars similarly observed, employees at the institution under study revealed that there was no succession planning put in place.

Still in the context of HEI in the US, King (2019) used mixed method in investigating how succession planning and leadership development are being implemented in 37 public HEIs in Texas. The study found that while more Texas universities were involving themselves into more formal leadership development programs, it was concerning, however, that there are only two institutions that were involved in formal succession planning, and only a meager 57% of the 37 still lack a formal leadership development program. Here, he made a distinction between official succession planning and leadership programs. The former being "a deliberate plan and procedure for identifying successors for leadership positions, while the latter refers to "an organized program or initiative aimed at improving the available 'bench-depth' of organizational leadership" (p. 57).

Moreover, he suggested that a leadership development program of HEIs should be created

that is specific to each state, funded by the state, and based within the state in order to enhance the existing national programs.

In an effort to comprehend how executive leadership and administrators in HEIs engaged in SP as part of their overall organizational strategy, Morrow (2023), employed interpretive phenomenological analysis to explore the experiences of HEI leaders with SP initiatives and the cultivation of internal leaders to fill vacant leadership positions. A significant theme that emerged from this analysis aligns with previous findings by other researchers, indicating that leaders have faced a deficit of SP strategies established in their organizations, which they attribute to a dominant organizational culture overshadowing a focus on developmental midnsets.

While the general consensus among these studies suggests that a formal SP is invariably linked to HEI's success, Hatcher (2023) in her scoping literature review of SP in HEIs had specifically identified that formal SP had significant contribution to (a) knowledge management and (b) employee retention in an HEI. The review also corroborated the earlier suggestions that top management plays a crucial role in the realization of an SP strategy in their institutions and human resources management should integrate and implement SP in their practice.

Hatcher (2023) added, however, an insightful recommendation which could have been missed out by previous studies and that is in order for an SP to succeed HEIs must be keen in aligning their SP strategy with their own organizational culture specifically using the servant leadership as a theory in implementing SP - a relatively different take as most SP studies (e.g. Adadevoh et al., 2024; Ahmad et al., 2024) had used the transformative leadership paradigm as a lens in their inquiry.

With most of these studies being done in the first world countries and chiefly centered on the western perspective, the need for new research contexts that would yield generalizability and

improve understanding of succession planning theories and practices has been highly opportune (Omar & Hassan, 2015). Studies from Africa (particularly Ghana) and Asia (chiefly Malaysia) have compelling findings and insights to share with the current scholarship. Studies in Malaysia have essentially equated succession planning to sustainable leadership as many have observed the impending leadership crisis across spectrum of leadership roles in Malaysian HEIs due mainly to changing demographics and the lack of potential leaders to replace the incumbents (Ghazali et al., 2021). Moreover, the Malaysian government sees HEIs, in particular public HEIs, to have profound contribution in sustaining its high growth nation status associating succession planning as a cornerstone for sustainability, stability, and continuity of HEIs (Omar & Hassan, 2015).

They see the lack of SP in public HEI as a problem that can bring negative consequences including among others wasted time and resources and low employee morale due to poor decisions made by unsuitable candidates (Chia et al., 2021). Hence, it was no surprising when Malaysian authorities through its Ministry of Higher Education took cognizance of SP as an integral part of public HEIs management strategy and initiated a nationwide SP program for academicians in 2016 (Chia et al., 2021).

This is very interesting and intriguing as this is the first and only instance in the literature where a national government took charge of SP for HEIs as earlier studies revealed that SP has been primarily an institutional concern and not a bureaucratic one. This move of the federal government of Malaysia created the Higher Education Leadership Academy (known locally as AKEPT) whose primary goal is to "develop holistic, quality, respected, and competent academic and administrative leaders who could lead local higher learning institutions to international heights" (Higher Education Leadership Academy, in Chia et al., 2021, p. 51).

Another interesting factor that prevents other HEI for successfully implementing SP is the tendency of many public HEIs to reward "research excellence over leadership capabilities" (Chia et al., 2021, p. 54). This leads to massive exodus of talents from the universities to other institutions with much lucrative benefits and salary packages to offer. The idea of seniority in leadership succession was also found to be a limiting factor why HEIs lack legitimate SP in their context.

In relation to leadership identification as one of the emerging themes in the literature, some scholars have focused on identifying competencies of individuals and proposing competency-based model in implementing SP. Ghazhali et al., (2021) forwarded the Competency-Based Succession Planning framework which puts individual competency at the center of the SP framework and identifies leadership training, personality traits, and organizational culture as key elements influencing it.

Drawing from this initial study, Ghazhali (2023) through a combination of exploratory and confirmatory factor analyses, statistically analyzed responses from HEI administrators and concluded that interpersonal, personal effectiveness, teamwork, and self-development as key measure of employee competency essential for SP.

Elsewhere in the literature, the quantitative study of Bano et al., (2022) showed the positive correlation between succession planning strategies and employee retention signaling that a well-established SP in an HEI can lessen employee turn-over and make employees stay longer in the institution. Similarly, Ishak et al., (2016) correlated key predictors for SP success in an HEI. They found out that knowledge management and career development significantly influence the successful institutionalization of SP in an HEI.

Organizational culture: Definition and Models

Organizational culture (henceforth, OC) is a critical aspect of any institution, influencing its effectiveness, employee behavior, and overall success. Drawing from various perspectives (anthropology, psychology, sociology, education), the term organizational culture had been defined in many ways over the years by scholars to encapsulate various realities that from different organization context (Keerio et al., 2022). For the purpose of comparison, here are few of widely known definitions put forth by scholars.

Pettigrew (1979) is perhaps one of the early scholars that investigated OC, he defined OC as "the system of publicly and collectively accepted meanings, operating for a given group, at a given time. This system of terms, forms, categories and images interpret a peoples' own situation to themselves" (p. 576).

In their extensive review of more than a hundred articles, Deshpande and Webster (1989) provided a similar perspective, defining OC as "the pattern of shared values and beliefs that help individuals understand organisational functioning and thus provide them with the norms for behaviour in the organisation" (p. 4).

Similarly, Shadzad and colleagues (2012) described organizational culture as a socially constructed characteristic of an organization which acts a social adhesive that united employees and instills a sense of belonging within the organization.

Moreover, for most researchers, organizational culture includes a shared array of values, behaviors, norms, attitudes, assumptions, and beliefs of the members of an organization (Dension et al., 2015; Belias & Koustellos, 2014; Paais & Pattiruhu, 2020; Scott & Allen, 2022).

From these definitions, scholars have proposed various models to explain the construct of OC. Schein's Model is one of the most widely recognized frameworks for understanding

organizational culture. Another widely recognized model is that of Hofstede's Cultural Dimensions Theory. This model examines how cultural values influence organizational behavior (Jacob, 2023).

Lastly, considered by some scholars (e.g. Demissie & Egziabher, 2022; Keerio et al., 2022) as one of the credible frameworks made is the Competing Values Framework (henceforth. CVF) developed by Quinn and Rohrbaugh (1983). This model proves to be highly beneficial for identifying a diverse array of organizational phenomena, encompassing organizational structure, organizational excellence, phases of life cycle progression, responsibilities of HR managers and leadership positions, effectiveness theories, and managerial competencies.

From this model, Cameron and Quinn (2011) divides OC into four culture domains: "clan culture; adhocracy culture, market culture and hierarchical culture" (in Demissie & Egziabher, 2022, p. 3). Organizations with a market culture focus on external success and profitability, often prioritizing customer satisfaction and market share. Lastly, hierarchy culture values order, consistency, and control. These organizations have well-defined structures, procedures, and polices to ensure efficiency and predictability. Stability and smooth operations are key priorities (Demissie & Egziabher, 2022; Keerio et al., 2022).

In summary, OC serves as a vital determinant in shaping the effectiveness, behaviors, and success of institutions, scholars have defined OC from various perspectives, recognizing it as a complex interplay of values, beliefs, and behaviors .The models discussed above offer structured ways to understand and analyze OC. These frameworks emphasize how culture influences everything from employee engagement to organizational performance, providing a valuable lens through which to assess institutional dynamics.

Organizational culture in higher education

While the plethora of OC studies have been focused on the business world, some scholars have already recognized the importance of OC in the context of HEIs. Demissie and Egziabher (2022) observed that HEIs are no different from business organizations. HEIs are structured organizations with hierarchy and guided by their mission and vision. They have employees with various beliefs and practices and more importantly they operate to deliver service and achieve excellence.

Most studies of OC in HEIs have focused on case studies determining dominant culture(s) present in their institution (Demissie & Egziabher, 2022; Vasyakin et al, 2016), relating leadership styles, faculty performance, and OC (Jamali, et al., 2021), the role of OC in implementing changes in HEI (Mierzwa & Mierzwa, 2020), correlation between the type of organizational culture and behavior of leaders (Kaufman, 2013), comparative study between public and private HEIs' OC (Debski et al. 2020), and elements of OC in HEIs (Coman, 2016).

From these sample studies, it can be deduced that OC in HEIs is a significant determinant of institutional performance, shaping how staff, faculty, and students interact and achieve goals. HEIs possess a unique OC characterized by academic freedom, shared governance, and traditions that influence behaviors and decision making (Tierney, 1988). In higher education, OC impacts teaching, learning, innovation, and faculty performance. Variations in OC across institutions stem from history, leadership styles, and external pressures, which can create challenges in institutional adaptability and transformation (Kezar & Eckel, 2002).

Moreover, Kezar and Eckel (2022) argue that a significant challenge facing HEI is maintaining alignment between organizational culture and evolving demands (i.e. globalization, changing student needs, technological advancements). Another issue raised in the literature is the

possible tension between academic and administrative culture. Bergquist and Palawak (2008) argue that these two cultures can create friction, as academic culture values autonomy and intellectual freedom, while administrative culture often focuses on efficiency, resource management, and accountability.

Elsewhere in the literature, scholars have identified that institutional type, leadership, mission and vision, history and traditions, and external environment are key factors that contribute to the development and maintenance of organizational culture in higher education (Demissie & Egziabher, 2022; Jerab & Mabrouk, 2023; Coman & Bonciu, 2016; Jacob, 2013). These factors have substantial implications for the efficiency and overall performance of HEIs. More specifically, OC can influence employee and student engagement as positive and supportive organizational culture can result in increased motivation, job satisfaction, and academic achievement (Demissie & Egziabher, 2022). OC also affects institutional change and innovation as a culture that encourages creativity and risk-taking can facilitate innovation and adaptation to new challenges and opportunities (Bogale & Debela, 2024; Coman & Bonciu, 2016). Lastly, a strong OC that aligns with institution's mission and goals can enhance its overall effectiveness and performance (Amtu et al., 2021; Demissie & Egziabher, 2022; Aryani & Widodo, 2020)

In a nutshell, OC is HEI is complex and multidimensional concept, deeply influencing how institutions operate and respond to internal and external challenges. The ability of HEIs to adapt their culture to changing societal and educational expectations while preserving core values is crucial for their long-term success. By understanding the dynamics of OC, leaders can better navigate the complexities of governance, innovation, and transformation within higher education.

The Role of HEI Leaders in Succession Planning and Organizational Culture

Also notable in the literature is the weight that many scholars have put in the role of leaders in SP. Chia et al. (2021) for example put emphasis on the role of leaders in the success of SP in HEIs arguing that leaders' perspectives on SP holds great significance as their views directly impact the effectiveness of SP within an organization. Consequently, current leaders must seriously consider succession planning to ensure that universities adopt systematic and comprehensive SP practices and policies. Shamsuddin et al., (2012) echoed the same position explaining that today's leaders are tasked with the duty of guaranteeing a seamless handover of leadership, backed by an effective system for developing leaders.

For Ghazali et al., (2023), succession planning and talent management should fall within the ambit of the current leadership of HEIs emphasizing the role of top management in ensuring leadership pipeline is established. Ahmad et al., (2024) even went as far as opining that during recruitment top management should integrate the qualities of potential leaders required in the organization and this should be aligned with the organization's objectives. They further added that current leadership has important role to play insofar as providing inspiration and mentorship to prospective leaders, hence forwarding transformational leadership as a viable leadership style to be applied in Malaysian public HEI context calling for current leaders to begin training "future leaders to succeed in leadership positions" (p. 181).

With respect to OC, existing research has highlighted the significant importance of leaders in molding and influencing the OC of their respective HEIs. Leaders serve as creators of culture, establishing the atmosphere, conveying principles, and demonstrating behaviors that spread

throughout the organization. As a result, leaders are the main catalysts of change within HEIs. Their actions and choices can either maintain or revolutionize OC, aligning it with strategic goals or permitting cultural values to shift (Jerab & Mabrouk, 2023).

Statement of the Problem

Current literature has acknowledged the benefits of SP predominantly in the corporate world and constrainedly in the academe and how these constructs have largely been applied to western settings; however, the influence of OC in SP has not been well-established in HEIs, particularly in the Philippine public HEI context. The significance of this gap lies in the necessity to comprehend these cultural dynamics for the improvement of leadership development and the facilitation of smooth leadership transitions in SUCs. This, in turn, can contribute to enhancing institutional effectiveness and long-term sustainability. Therefore, this study attempted to answer this research question:

How organizational culture influences succession planning in HEIs within the Philippine context, specifically in state universities and colleges.

There is a necessity to answer this question as it will have a tremendous impact on the future of SUCs in the country. A sound SP will ensure that future leaders of SUCs are carefully and strategically identified and are exposed to leadership development programs to prepare them for their future roles thereby providing stability and continuity and ensuring institutional memory and essential organizational culture are transferred to the next batch of leaders in the pipeline.

Methods

Given the complexities and intricacies of succession planning practices, as well as the influence of the prevailing organizational culture within SUCs and the role that their leaders play in leadership transitions, this study employed a qualitative approach to answer the research question. Specifically, thematic analysis was employed to analyze the responses of the target participants.

Research Setting

Currently, there are 113 state universities and colleges (henceforth, SUC) with 433 satellite campuses operating under the supervision of the Commission on Higher Education (CHED), distributed across 17 regions of the country, ranging from large institutions with multiple campuses to smaller regional colleges. These comprise roughly 23% of the entire HEIs in the country, both public and private (CHED, 2023).

Each SUC operates under its respective charter enacted as a Republic Act by Congress and approved by the President of the Republic of the Philippines. Under these charters, SUCs are governed either by a Board of Regents (for state universities) or a Board of Trustees (for state colleges) composed of 11-12 members from across various stakeholders (i.e. alumni representatives, faculty union president, staff union presidents, student council president, University Presidents, a Senator, a House Representative, Regional Directors/Secretaries of National Economic Development Authority, Department of Agriculture, Department of Science and Technology, Generals of Philippine Air force and Philippine Navy, and private sector representatives). All Boards are chaired by the Chairperson of CHEd or a Commissioner-designate

chosen by the Chair from among the other Commissioners of CHEd. Together, acting as a collegial body, they promulgate policies that will essentially set the direction of each SUC they govern.

These institutions are significant players in the country's education landscape, enrolling nearly 2 million students as of 2023, accounting for almost 39% of the total higher education population in the Philippines (CHED, 2023). For the last few years, SUCs have been the source of the local workforce producing roughly 300,000 graduates every year, underscoring their essential role in national development (CHED, 2023).

In the Philippines, SUCs play a fundamental role in providing accessible and quality education across diverse regions. However, the leadership challenges these institutions face, including political interference, resource constraints, and a rapidly changing educational environment, necessitate a structured approach to leadership development, hence the importance of SP. The Second Congressional Commission on Education took cognizance of this when they put 'building leadership capacity in SUCs and LUCs' under 'Efficiency of public and private higher education provision' as one of the top five (5) priority areas and issues of inquiry in higher education in the country adding more credence to its importance.

The dynamic and unique landscape of higher education in the Philippines necessitates a careful examination of SP practices in SUCs, whether informal or formal, and the role that OC plays in their institutionalization or otherwise. As SUCs face increasing demands for accountability, academic excellence, and global competitiveness, the institutionalization of SP, whether at the bureaucratic or institutional level, becomes inevitably essential and perhaps soon obligatory. Delving into the intricacies of SP and OC in SUCs will prove beneficial in ensuring that policy aligns with practices and the realities on the ground, making any attempt at policy reform much more responsive and contextualized.

To conclude, SUCs of today face unique challenges in leadership, particularly in developing and identifying future leaders, due to varying levels of autonomy, budgetary constraints, organizational culture, and even political interference (Palencia, 2015; Yee, 2022).

Participants

The sampling method for this study was purposive, specifically targeting 15 Middle Managers/Administrators (i.e., Deans, Directors, Heads of Offices) from select State Universities and Colleges (SUCs) across the Philippines, as they hold critical roles in the leadership transition processes within their institutions. As middle administrators, they bring unique insights into both the formal succession planning mechanisms and the cultural and bureaucratic constraints impacting them. The inclusion criteria are the following:

For SUCs:

1. Level III SUC for at least 5 years
2. Medium-sized SUC (based on DBM-NBC No. 589, s. 2022)

For target interviewees:

1. Middle Managers of SUCs (Deans, Directors, Heads of offices);
2. With at least 3 consecutive years of experience in their current role; and
3. Must have been affiliated with their current university for the last 10 consecutive years

Instrument

To capture a comprehensive view of the realities and challenges of succession planning within the unique organizational context of their respective SUCs, select SUC leaders were personally interviewed to gain their insights. This research employed semi-structured interviews with open-ended questions, specifically designed to understand not only the direct experiences and practices of key institutional actors but also to reveal the underlying factors, such as cultural norms, bureaucratic structures, and political influences, that shape these experiences. Follow-up questions were asked to probe deeper into the participants' responses, ensuring the collection of rich and comprehensive data. Each interview lasted approximately 45 to 60 minutes.

Procedure

After gaining approval from the University Research Ethics Office, the target participants were formally invited to participate in the study via email and official communication channels. The invitation included an information sheet that explained the study's purpose, scope, potential risks, and benefits, as well as an informed consent form for participants to sign before the interview. After obtaining consent, interviews were scheduled at the participants' convenience. The researcher ensured a quiet, comfortable environment for the interviews, whether conducted face-to-face or via Zoom, depending on the interviewees' preference.

All interview transcripts and recordings were securely stored on password-protected devices and folders to maintain confidentiality and avoid data breaches. Each participant was assigned a pseudonym to ensure anonymity during data analysis and reporting.

Data Analysis

The audio recordings were transcribed verbatim, and the transcripts were reviewed for accuracy. Using critical realism as lens (Archer's (2020) Structure, Agency, & Culture) in the coding and analysis of data, reflexive thematic analysis of Fryer (2022) and Wiltshire and Ronkainen (2021) were employed in identifying the themes (dispositional, inferential, and experiential themes) from the transcript. For the accuracy of identifying themes, inter-coding was conducted between the researcher and a recognized expert in the field.

Results and Discussion

This section presents a summary of overarching themes that emerged from the interview transcripts. Using Archer's (2005) Structure, Agency, and Culture framework, this section analyzed the complex interplay among structural, cultural, and individual and/or institutional dynamics present in the following themes and show their alignment with existing literature and offer novel insights into the unique sociopolitical and cultural landscape of Philippine state universities and colleges.

Table 1. Dispositional and Inferential Themes

Dispositional Themes	Inferential Themes
Formal Succession Planning Policy is not in place	- Leader-centric decision making in SP - Appointment of leaders is inconsistent and does not follow a specified criterion
The inextricable role of politics in SP	- The interplay of internal politics and leadership - The interplay of external politics and leadership
Commitment to institutional development	- Leadership transition as a necessity for institutional sustainability - Recognition of gaps in institutional policies re SP - Involvement of stakeholders in the selection of top management
Statutory regulations as hindrance to institutionalization of SP	- Navigating complex bureaucratic oversight

Formal Succession Planning Policy is not in place

This theme highlights a common practice and observation in many academic institutions particularly in HEIs where succession planning is not governed by a well-defined, formal policy. (Barton, 2017; King, 2019; Morrow, 2023; Richards, 2016; Richards, 2009; Swanson, 2018).

Instead, leadership transitions and appointments are often guided by informal mechanism, cultural norms, or ad hoc practices. This illustrates how structural gaps constrain individual and even collective agency to transform the organization and instead reinforce a culture of informality.

> *There was no actual process or guidelines on how to transition. (MM1, 144)*
>
> *The absence of policy. Perhaps the reason why you are asking this question is, you're interested on researching. If there are policies, what are those policies? And maybe I can directly go to the point that there is no written policy asking for transition and succession, especially when it comes to leadership, at least in our University. (MM2, 219-244).*

Simultaneously, this entrenched institutional norm that prioritizes tradition and informal practices over a systematic policy perpetuate structural stagnancy which makes formalizing an SP plan much more challenging.

The absence of a clear-cut policies regarding leadership transition could potentially lead to tension between and among members of the institution resulting to a divided and fractured organizational culture that could eventually pull down its performance and derail its strategic direction. More so, this could possibly encourage a culture of resistance to institutionalizing SP dismissing it as a mere immediate need rather than a strategic plan toward institutional stability and sustainability.

Leader-centric decision making in SP

Since the institution lacks a formal SP policy, this leads to reliance on leaders, thereby revealing leader-centric practices as part of the institution's organizational culture. Given the predominantly hierarchical nature of leadership structure in SUCs as bureaucratic agencies, this lack of SP also unwittingly consolidates the power to one entity (usually the University Presidents) giving them wide latitude of discretionary power, enabling them to dominate succession planning process.

> *Oh, historically, in our university it is always the prerogative of the University President. We would like to think that we are chosen because of our capabilities the alignment of our educational background, experience, and expertise to the nature of tasks that we are going to fulfill. But looking at the macro perspective. I think it would be trust and confidence. That's the main consideration of the President assigning his or her immediate assistance in fulfilling her role as the leader of a university. (MM3, 50-55)*

In this set-up, leaders' agency is highly pronounced as they hold the power to shape and reshape succession outcomes through personal judgements or relationships. While this can able greater flexibility and responsiveness, this often comes at the cost of inclusivity, transparency, and accountability. Leaders may now prioritize trust, loyalty, or alignment with their vision over merit-based and democratic, participatory processes, which can limit the establishment of a robust talent pipeline and discourage broader involvement of community (e.g. faculty, staff, and student consultations) and other stakeholders in decision-making. Moreover, a leader-centric decision-making practice can eventually lead to a leader-dependent culture rather than fostering a system

inspired by shared governance that can independently stand alone and can transcend tenures of leaders.

Appointment of leaders is inconsistent and does not follow a specified criterion

As leaders have now consolidated their powers on SP decision-making, the structure now relies heavily on the leaders' prerogative. This now leads to inconsistencies and possible discrepancies in their decisions. This discretion amplifies variability in decision-making creating confusion and perhaps distrust from among the members of the academic community affecting institutional and individual morale. These inconsistencies reveal the institution's inability to implement a specific, rules-based selection process and criteria.

> *I think, it would be case to case basis. There are instances where in the the selection is really ideal. But there are also instances that it just come out even sometimes a through a haphazard decision. (MM10, 151-153)*
>
> *Sad to say again, there's no there's no criteria set. No, it's just merely how the designating official know the person in terms of his behavior, her behavior, her background, her track record. And I would like to highlight that. There's no event. There's no mechanism in place evaluating university officials although we have a performance evaluation mechanisms, but that would only capture specific transactions, for example, teaching submitting documents. But leaders are not usually evaluated. (MM6, 431-436)*

The absence of formal SP policy puts Philippine SUCs at a disadvantage compared to global best practices, where institutions (i.e. Malaysian, American, Canadian HEIs) are increasingly adopting dynamic and competency-based SP frameworks (Chia et al., 2021; Ghazali et al., 2021; Omar & Hassan, 2015; Rothwell, 2015).

Statutory regulations as hindrance to institutionalization of SP

While the earlier noted themes show the status quo of SP in SUCs, it is important to dig deeper into causal powers and mechanisms that led to this problem. One intriguing factor that could be linked to this is the limiting power that statutory regulations impose on SUCs.

Navigating complex bureaucratic oversight

These overarching policies serve as an external force that act as barrier thereby constraining the organization from effectively institutionalizing their own SP policy. Regulatory policies in effect force institutions to adopt a compliance-driven culture rather than exercise their own agency to experiment on their context-specific SP policy that aligns with their long-term strategic objectives - a similar call made by King (2019) in her study of 37 Texan public HEI in the US.

> *Correct, correct, because, we have to comply with that. If not, it would always be an observation every once in a while that we are undergoing accreditation. (MM8, 75-76)*
>
> *In terms of the program chairperson. I would like to say that this is a more what? Aligned with a distinct set of criteria, because, there are memorandum orders that we have to comply as to the qualifications of the chairpersons, and sometimes they are, including the Dean. Now, having specialized, or a particular doctorate degree alignment of the degree to the programs being offered under a particular college. So there is a much, I think, stringent criteria for for the program chairperson. (MM9, 63-69)*
>
> *1st is, there's no training there is no, it's hard to assume a very particular, a particular office responsibility when it is governed by many laws no, many memorandum circular that has come over not only a decade, but many decades*

> *In order for you to be effective, you should have encountered, or at least have read a memorandum circular that is as old as you released sometime in 1990, which is still prevailing out of the moment. (MM4, 335-339)*

The restrictive structure that these external policies exert on SUCs have led to a regulatory-centric mindset and overreliance on procedures instead of being proactive in adopting institution-centric practices that could yield to the promulgation of the SUCs own SP policies. Over regulation therefore curtails leaders from engaging in collaborative and creative process of designing their own SP policy.

The inextricable role of politics in SP

Another player that could have influenced the non-institutionalization of SP policy in SUCs is politics – both internal and external.

The interplay of external politics and leadership

The SUCs structural alignment and cultural relationship with government agencies make it inexcusable from being infiltrated by political actors and forces from making decisions with regard to leadership transitions. The structural legal framework (i.e. their Charters) from which SUCs are derived from have inevitably made this possible. The usually 11-member Board of Regents / Board of Trustees are often composed of one (1) Senator and (1) House Representative, officials (usually regional directors) from national government agencies like National Economic Development Authority, Department of Science and Technology, and the Department of Agriculture. All can exercise and exert political influence over decisions made regarding SP as they are vested with approving/disproving powers by the SUCs charter. Notwithstanding, the interference of local government unit officials which also sometimes yield political influence as SUCs are mandated to partner with them in various capacities such as research and extension

collaborations. University officials particularly university presidents have no choice but to balance institutional priorities and political patronage from these actors to avoid risk of political backlash (e.g. budget cut). This intricate relationship (often a love and hate one) between university officials and political actors create an ecosystem of political dependency and institutional inhibition which limits the SUCs from pursuing an impartial and merit-based leadership transition strategies.

> *Of course we cannot take away in the picture that there is politics revolving around this this aspect of managing a university. So, aside from the fact that we are an instrument of the government, so I think even private institutions would have their own stories of how politics revolve around major decision of their university or their company. So politics would play a big role in in these concerns, in the questions that you're asking. (MM8, 162-166)*
>
> *I think, both because, yeah, because the President could could also be influenced by you bigger forces, such as recommendations from a national agency, a national, political figure, or he could be influenced by his own circle of network of people. No, so it's an interplay of both the external and the internal. (MM4, 171-174).*
>
> *I've been to a private school as an as a student, and somehow I I become a student leader. So I see how offices transact, you know. So when I enter Government service and enter into State University, I saw the the politics play a big role. No in its daily operation, much more in coming up with major decisions. So I think that's 1. No, we are a government institution, and we can never be exempted in experiencing the atmosphere of politics. (MM7, 232-236)*

The interplay of internal politics and leadership

In addition to the complicated influence of external political forces in SUCs, the interview has also revealed the unique role that internal political dynamics within SUCs play in SP. As Richards (2009) and Morrow (2023) noted, organizational culture, which include internal political dynamics, can inadvertently impact approaches to SP.

Just like any other institutions, SUCs are also susceptible to being run by unseen yet often dominating internal political climate that have huge impact in leadership transition and continuity whether positively or adversely These political dynamics are often governed by unwritten rules that members of the institution adhere to whether voluntarily or reluctantly often shaped by people in various (often opposing) groups or camps whose allegiances are bonded by friendship, personal agendas, and alignment of values. These cultural dynamics can cause discontent and may undermine trust and collaboration as members of the institution may perceive leadership decisions as politically motivated rather than objectively rendered. Hence, the actors with political influence can hinder efforts to institutionalize a fair, transparent, and merit-based SP.

> *Of course we cannot take away in the picture that there is politics revolving around this this aspect of managing a university. So, aside from the fact that we are an instrument of the government, so I think even private institutions would have their own stories of how politics revolve around major decision of their university or their company. So politics would play a big role in in these concerns, in the questions that you're asking. (MM12, 162-166)*
>
> *The best example is making their children an employee of trying their best to to give a spot a slot for their children to become members also of the same institution. We cannot take away that they can influence the hiring process.*

> *They can directly send a message to people who are in charge of the hiring process, much more the major decision of selecting which is the President, or who is the President? They do that. So I think. Politics is really there. (MM10, 278-281)*
>
> *So they have once a hold power and major decision making in the university. So that's what I mean by the the politics, although we might say that politics interplay with power. And I think what I'm explaining is politics even among colleagues, even among ordinary faculty members, as you say, is small key players. They are all. There are also politics between them the dynamics of their relationship as colleagues, as both members of the faculty. (MM8, 260-265)*

Commitment to institutional development

While the earlier themes have expounded on the roles of organizational practices that could have led to the absence of SP policy, there were, however, some promising insights that might soon lead to the institutionalization of SP in SUCs. Here, we can argue that leader's initiatives play pivotal role in directing or redirecting institutional development goals. Leaders with strong commitment can leverage their prerogatives to spearhead policies and programs that are congruent with the long-term and short-term strategic goals of the university or college. Hence, this commitment can inspire structural and even cultural reform within the institution,

This corroborates the argument made by Hatcher (2023) on her assumptions that leaders play a crucial role in the realization of an SP strategy in their respective institutions.

Recognition of gaps in institutional policies re SP

This commitment may begin with objectively recognizing first what the institution lacks and needs to be addressed so institutional reform could begin. Acknowledging gaps in SP policies is a necessary first step towards understanding its complexities which can in turn direct the institution to reflect on their current practices and to identify which of these practices need to be changed and which new practices may be added so a merit-based and transparent system for SP can be put into place.

> *And the hoping no hoping that other universities are already having established models as to how they are doing this, so that we can benchmark and say that there is really a need for our University to adapt to to these things, because these are present in our in other universities or our counterparts in other universities. (MM3, 224-227)*

Leadership transition as a necessity for institutional sustainability

Another intriguing insight that emerged from the themes is the recognition of SP's importance to institutional sustainability. This signals the crucial role that SP play in institutional stability and continuity thereby signaling the necessity of implementing SP strategies such as mentoring and leadership development program. Moreover, this commitment underscores the culture of strategic planning, collaboration, and inclusivity towards leadership transition and view this as growth opportunity. Setting this norm within SUCs can also ease internal political tension and can minimize external political control over leaders and their SP decisions.

> *So that's one establish a particular period where succession and transition should happen, not only for a day, for a meeting it should be a a particular*

> *period, we should think of it. We should study it well. How long this transition should be? (MM6, 484-487)*
>
> *This is already leadership. We're not only dealing with personal skills per personality attributes. We're dealing with the technical know how also of the people. And most importantly, decision making these are live skills, as a world health organization would call it. It is a life skill? No, for every individuals, much more. It should be a competency for people holding a high ranking positions, particularly in the University. (MM9, 376-380)*

Involvement of stakeholders in the selection of top management

Finally, the most promising insight that the themes have revealed is the attempt of SUCs to involve stakeholders in the selection of top management. This signals the willingness of the leaders to commit to institutionalizing a merit-based, rules-governed SP- a willingness to change the prevailing structure and inspire cultural transformation, a result Swanson (2018) similarly articulated.

A positive development towards recognizing the importance of SP in leadership stability and continuity. A clear inclination towards a systematic process of leadership selection and transition that is transparent and accountable and less likely to yield to external and internal political setbacks.

> *And recently there are initiatives of setting up a criteria for positions like the Vice President and letting the community and other stakeholders of the university be involved, such as voting among faculty members among other officials, and including alumni and the Who else? Other stakeholders? No, yeah. (MM3, 55-58)*

The data collected may be arguably small and limited, it is important to infer however that just like in other HEI contexts and different organizations in the world as observed by some researchers (Ahmad, 2019; Hatcher, 2023, Mehrtak, 2017), organizational culture has undeniable and inextricable influence over succession planning.

While it was revealed in the earlier discussion that the absence of an SP policy has been largely influenced by both external and internal factors which made up the prevailing organizational culture of the SUC, it is worth noting though that there are signs of reform in the horizon.

And on the prospect of these reforms being implemented in the future, that is still uncertain. What is clear though is that there are now tiny steps being undertaken towards that direction.

Conclusion

The findings of this study illustrate the complex and often contradictory realities surrounding succession planning (SP) in Philippine State Universities and Colleges (SUCs). Guided by Archer's (2005) Structure, Agency, and Culture framework, the results expose how the absence of formal SP policies, leader-centric decision-making, political interference, and bureaucratic constraints collectively sustain a fragmented and informal system of leadership transition. This interplay of structural gaps, cultural norms, and individual agency reveals an organizational culture that is simultaneously resistant to formal change yet increasingly aware of its institutional vulnerabilities.

The persistence of informal, personality-driven succession practices reinforces short-term, leader-dependent governance at the expense of long-term institutional sustainability. Moreover, the entanglement of both external and internal political forces in leadership selection undermines

efforts to create transparent, merit-based, and participatory SP processes. These realities place Philippine SUCs at a disadvantage compared to international higher education institutions that have embraced systematic, competency-driven SP models.

Nonetheless, the study also surfaces emerging pockets of reform. The expressed commitment to institutional development, recognition of policy gaps, and growing efforts to involve stakeholders in leadership selection represent promising cultural shifts towards building a more resilient, transparent, and sustainable leadership pipeline. These developments signal the possibility—albeit gradual and uncertain—of institutionalizing SP as both a strategic and cultural priority.

Ultimately, the results underscore the need for Philippine SUCs to move beyond compliance-driven, politically influenced structures and foster leadership transitions anchored on inclusivity, meritocracy, and strategic foresight. Doing so requires not only structural reforms but also a deliberate cultural transformation that reframes leadership as a shared, institutionally embedded responsibility rather than an individual prerogative. As this study suggests, while deep-seated challenges persist, pathways toward a more accountable and future-proof leadership system are beginning to emerge—one that recognizes the inextricable relationship between structure, culture, and agency in shaping the future of higher education leadership in the Philippines.

Implications

The study's findings reveal significant implications for succession planning in Philippine SUCs. The absence of formal SP policies, inconsistent leadership selection criteria, and political influences highlight the urgent need for policy reforms, leadership development programs on

institutional and bureaucratic levels, and mechanisms for stakeholder engagement. Structural reform and cultural shift to transparency, meritocracy and collaboration are essential for ensuring leadership sustainability.

This research also extends the recent scholarship on SP and OC by providing a localized perspective where political dynamics, cultural norms, and structural gaps play significant roles. The findings likewise highlight the importance of contextualizing SP theories to accommodate the unique sociopolitical and cultural realities of Philippine SUCs.

By unearthing the pervasive role of politics in SP, this study bridges political and organizational theories by demonstrating that leadership transition in HEIs are not solely organizational decisions but are influenced by broader political and power structures. Studies on this interdisciplinary are may be conducted in the future to expand our understanding of SP as a multifaceted bureaucratic process in HEIs.

In the broader context, the results show the importance of leadership trait as a critical factor to institutional adaptability and strategic foresight in HEIs viewing leadership not just as a technical competency but as a relational and culturally embedded practice.

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